

## Ethical Issues in Writing

|                                        | Meaning                                                                                                           | Examples                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Suppression of Information</b>      | Burying to data to hide inconvenient truths                                                                       | A company fails to reveal product-testing results that indicate potential danger to consumers                                                                                       |
| <b>Falsification or fabrication</b>    | Changing or inventing data to support a desired outcome                                                           | A company boasts of a fictitious enterprise to lure investors into supporting a new venture                                                                                         |
| <b>Overstatement or understatement</b> | Exaggerating the positive aspects of a situation of downplaying negative aspects to create the desired impression | A public-opinion survey describes 55 percent of the respondents as a “substantial majority” and 45 percent as “a small percentage”                                                  |
| <b>Selective misquoting</b>            | Deleting words from quoted material to distort meaning                                                            | A supervisor changes a report’s conclusion that “this proposal will seem feasible only to workers unfamiliar with the situation” to “this proposal will seem feasible.. to workers” |
| <b>Subjective Wording</b>              | Using terms deliberately chosen for their ambiguity                                                               | A company advertises “customary service charges”, knowing that “customary” is open to broad interpretation.                                                                         |
| <b>Conflict of interest</b>            | Exploiting behind-the-scenes connections to influence decision-making                                             | A board member of a community agency encourages the agency to hire her company for paid services rather than soliciting bids                                                        |
| <b>Withholding information</b>         | Refusing to share relevant data with coworkers                                                                    | A computer-savvy employee provides misleading answers about new software to make recently hired coworker appear incompetent                                                         |
| <b>Plagiarism</b>                      | Taking credit for someone else’s ideas, findings                                                                  | An employee assigned to prepare a report written by someone at another company, downloaded from internet                                                                            |

## Communication in the Workplace

### A. Ethics in Workplace Communication (Bernales, et al., 2018)

Accuracy, honesty, and fairness should always be present in workplace communication. If a writer slants his/her words to conceal the truth or to gain an unfair advantage, he/she is not being ethical (Kolin, 2017). According to Searles (2014) as cited in Bernales, et al. (2018), workplace communication will fail the ethics test if it is corrupted by any of the following tactics:

#### 1. Suppression of information

Also known as "data suppression," it refers to the process of withholding or removing selected information or an inconvenient truth to protect an individual or a group (The Glossary of Education Reform, 2017). For example, if a pharmaceutical company intentionally hid their product-testing results that indicate potential danger to consumers, it is considered as data suppression.

#### 2. Falsification or fabrication

Falsification refers to changing or omitting data or results such that the research is not accurately represented in the research record. On the other hand, fabrication refers to the act of making up data or results (Office of Research Integrity, n.d.).

#### 3. Overstatement or understatement

Exaggerating the positive aspects of a situation or downplaying the negative aspects to create desired impression is unethical. For example, a social weather survey describes 55% of the respondents as a "substantial majority" while 45% is viewed as a "small percentage."

#### 4. Selective misquoting

According to Kolin (2017), it refers to "deliberate omission of damaging or unflattering comments to paint a better but untruthful picture of you or your company."

##### Selective misquotation:

"I've enjoyed... our firm's association with Advanced Computer Services, Inc. the quality of their service was... excellent."

##### Full quotation:

I've enjoyed at times our firm's association with Advanced Computer Services, Inc., although I was troubled by the uneven quality of their service. At times, it was excellent while at others it was far less so."

#### 5. Subjective wording

This refers to the intentional use of terms and words that will hide the real meaning of the situation.

##### Example:

A telecommunications company advertises "customary service charges" for its postpaid handset promos knowing that the term "customary" is open to broad interpretation.

#### 6. Conflict of interest

This occurs when a corporation or a person becomes unreliable or biased in his/her decisions because of a clash between personal and professional affairs (Investopedia, 2018).

##### Example:

Manager A encourages his department to hire his company as a service provider in a project rather than soliciting bids.

#### 7. Withholding information

Refusing to share important information or relevant data with coworkers is an unethical act especially if it would jeopardize the success of an ongoing project. Withholding information about operating a new software to gain an upper hand over a recently hired colleague to make the latter appear incompetent is a breach of workplace ethics.

There may be times that an information is temporarily withheld (e.g., If the information will affect national security, it unnecessarily violates the privacy and confidentiality rights of others, or it might lead to undue stigmatization of individuals or groups within society.). Eventually, the reasons for knowingly withholding information should be fully defensible and based on ethical considerations.

#### 8. Plagiarism

This refers to stealing someone's else's words, ideas, or even the results of a study and claiming them as your own without documenting (or even inadequately documenting) the source (Kolin, 2017).